

Andouille Jambalaya

A teaching recipe from Jake's Table. Southern-fusion one-pot jambalaya built for a home cooking class of eight. This recipe walks students through building flavor in layers - from a quick roux base through the trinity, proteins, and rice absorption - over a full three-hour session. Sourcing good andouille makes a measurable difference; Jake uses Cajun-style links from Buford Highway Farmers Market whenever possible.

Ingredients (serves 8)

Proteins

- 1 lb andouille sausage, sliced ¼ inch on the bias
- 1 lb boneless chicken thighs, cut into 1-inch pieces
- ½ lb medium shrimp, peeled and deveined (optional, add last 5 minutes)
- 2 tbsp neutral oil

Trinity and Aromatics

- 1 large yellow onion, diced
- 3 stalks celery, diced
- 1 large green bell pepper, diced
- 6 cloves garlic, minced
- 1 can (14 oz) fire-roasted diced tomatoes
- 3 tbsp tomato paste

Spice Blend

- 2 tsp smoked paprika
- 1 tsp cayenne (adjust to class heat preference)
- 1 tsp dried thyme
- 1 tsp dried oregano
- 1 tsp onion powder
- 1 tsp garlic powder
- Salt and black pepper to taste

Rice and Stock

- 2 cups long-grain white rice, rinsed
 - 4 cups chicken stock (low-sodium)
 - 2 bay leaves
 - Scallions and flat-leaf parsley for garnish
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Method

1. **Render the andouille.** Heat oil in a large Dutch oven or heavy-bottomed pot over medium-high. Add andouille slices and cook 3-4 minutes per side until deeply browned. Remove and set aside, leaving the

rendered fat in the pot.

2. **Brown the chicken.** Season chicken pieces with salt, pepper, and a pinch of paprika. Brown in the same pot in batches, 3-4 minutes per side. Do not crowd the pan. Remove and set aside with the andouille.

3. **Build the base roux.** Reduce heat to medium. Add 2 tbsp oil if the pot looks dry. Stir in 2 tbsp flour and cook, stirring constantly, for 3-4 minutes until the mixture turns a light peanut-butter color. This is a blond roux - not the dark 30-minute roux used for gumbo, but enough to add body and toasty depth.

4. **Sweat the trinity.** Add onion, celery, and bell pepper. Cook 6-8 minutes, stirring frequently, until softened and starting to caramelize. Scrape any browned bits from the bottom of the pot - that's flavor.

5. **Add garlic and tomato paste.** Stir in garlic and cook 1 minute. Add tomato paste and cook another 2 minutes until it darkens slightly and coats the vegetables.

6. **Bloom the spices.** Add the spice blend directly to the pot and stir to coat the vegetables. Cook 30 seconds. The heat activates the fat-soluble aromatics in the paprika and cayenne.

7. **Build the liquid base.** Add the fire-roasted tomatoes (with juice), then pour in the stock. Stir well to deglaze the pot. Add the bay leaves.

8. **Return the proteins.** Add the browned andouille and chicken back to the pot. Stir to combine. Bring to a gentle boil.

9. **Add the rice.** Stir in the rinsed rice. Make sure it is submerged. Reduce heat to low, cover tightly, and cook for 20 minutes without lifting the lid.

10. **Check and finish.** Lift the lid after 20 minutes. If rice is nearly tender but liquid remains, re-cover and cook 5 more minutes. If adding shrimp, nestle them into the pot now, cover, and cook 4-5 minutes until pink.

11. **Rest.** Remove from heat and let sit covered for 5 minutes. This finishes the rice and redistributes moisture.

12. **Serve.** Fluff gently with a fork. Discard bay leaves. Garnish with sliced scallions and chopped parsley. Serve directly from the pot, family-style.

Technique Notes

Roux safety: Even a blond roux gets hot. Keep stirring and warn students not to walk away - burnt roux is bitter and cannot be rescued. Keep a cup of stock nearby to cool the pot if the roux progresses too fast.

Layering seasoning: Season at each stage - the chicken before browning, the trinity as it softens, and a final taste-and-adjust before adding rice. Jambalaya should never need salt at the table if seasoned in layers.

Rice-to-liquid ratio: The 1:2 ratio (rice to stock) is correct here, but tomatoes and meat juices contribute additional liquid. If the pot looks dry at the 15-minute mark, add ¼ cup warm stock. If it looks soupy, leave the lid ajar for the final 5 minutes.

Resting: The 5-minute rest off heat is essential. Students always want to serve immediately. Enforce the rest - it is the difference between sticky, clumped jambalaya and distinct, tender grains.

Teaching Tips

This dish works well as a three-hour class anchor because the 20-minute rice simmer gives students time to prepare garnishes, clean their station, and discuss variations. Demo the roux and trinity build in real time - these are the two technique moments that make or break the dish.

- Prep the spice blend in small cups before class so students can smell each component separately
 - Have students take turns stirring the pot during the blond roux stage - builds muscle memory for heat control
 - Print the color chart showing blond, medium, and dark roux so students know what to aim for
 - Taste the dish at each major stage so students understand flavor development
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Variations

Seafood jambalaya: Omit the chicken. Use 1 lb shrimp and ½ lb bay scallops. Add both in the last 5 minutes of cooking. Increase cayenne slightly to balance the sweetness of the shellfish.

Vegetarian: Replace proteins with 1 can red kidney beans and 1 cup sliced mushrooms. Use vegetable stock. Add a smoked paprika-forward spice blend to compensate for the missing andouille smokiness.

Andouille-forward: Double the andouille and omit the chicken entirely. A simple, faster version well-suited to a 90-minute pop-up class format.